Furthermore, this strategy seamlessly blended the BJP's focus on social-welfare spending with the politics of social engineering and a planned outreach to attract those lower down the caste order into its fold. The choice of villages where this outreach took place (4,487 in UP) was dictated by caste composition, with party leaders targeting those with a greater share of lower-caste populations first. As Yogi summed up that night, 'Honourable PM [Modi] has chosen more than 20,000 villages in the country which we are reaching out to because SCs and deprived sections constitute more than half the population of these villages. We will reach out to them in the first phase, in the second phase to other villages, and then, in the third phase, to the whole nation. So, if 136 houses were approved in this village this year and 500 personal toilets, people should have this information. Which scheme is coming and which scheme will have what benefits? What does the Jan Dhana Yojana mean for them in benefits? When the PM talks of DBT [Direct Benefit Transfers] transactions, and if that money goes directly into labharthee accounts, what is the benefit of this? If someone has a Jan Dhan account, they can benefit from every government scheme. They can get money for a toilet, money for a house, get chulha [stove] subsidy benefits, benefits from pension schemes and many other schemes.' The messaging was plain to see and specially crafted for the cameras.

Yogi Adityanath followed up the midnight meeting with dinner at a local Dalit family's house and stayed the night in the village with his cabinet ministers. The headlines on Hindi news channels the next day were dominated by what Aaj Tak, the Hindi channel, called his 'Nayak' turn, in a reference to the Anil Kapoor-starrer *Nayak*, where a local reporter-turned-chief minister held public hearings of officials. TV coverage of the event also showcased the smiling wife of Dayaram Saroj, the Dalit host, proudly talking about her dinner guest and recounting the menu for the cameras: 'bhindi ki sabzi, raita, gurh, lauki ki sabzi, aam ki chutney, kheer, roti [okra, yoghurt, jaggery, bottle gourd, mango chutney, rice pudding, bread].'[1]